



supplementation under medical supervision.

Iron edge

Female athletes face additional challenges related to hormones and iron. Iron is needed to carry oxygen and maintain energy levels. When iron levels fall, energy and concentration drop. Low estrogen levels due to stress or diet can also reduce bone strength over time.

I make sure to understand how each athlete's nutrition and cycle affect energy and performance, and I adjust the plan accordingly. For younger players, I build diets rich in iron from leafy greens and lentils, and I combine these foods with Vitamin C for better absorption. Calcium and iron compete in the body, so timing is important. I often suggest keeping dairy products and iron-rich meals at least two hours apart.

Eat enough, not less

One of the most common but silent problems is low energy availability. When athletes burn more calories than they consume, the body

begins to conserve energy by reducing reproductive hormone production. This condition, known as Relative Energy Deficiency in Sport, can lead to loss of bone mass and a higher risk of fractures.

Many young athletes mistakenly believe that eating less will make them faster or lighter. The opposite happens. The body weakens. Bones become fragile. Recovery slows. I always explain that eating adequately is not indulgence — it is part of training.

Traditional route

Indian food offers many natural ways to strengthen bones. I prefer using local ingredients because they are familiar and sustainable:

- ✦ *Ragi* or finger millet is one of the best plant sources of calcium.

- ✦ Sesame seeds or *til* provide calcium, magnesium and healthy fats.

- ✦ Curry leaves are rich in micronutrients that support bone metabolism.

- ✦ *Paneer* and curd offer calcium and probiotics for gut health.

Beneath the flesh: Behind sporting successes are years of science-based nutrition, dedication and a commitment to understanding how to protect and strengthen the skeleton.

EMMANUEL YOGINI

- ✦ Drumstick leaves and *methi* supply iron, calcium and fibre.

For vegetarian athletes, pairing pulses and grains — such as *dal* with rice or *khichdi* — provides a complete protein profile.

Tests are the best

Every athlete should monitor bone health regularly. I suggest DEXA scans for bone density, blood tests for Vitamin D and iron, and routine diet assessments. These tools help catch small issues before they turn serious. Nutrition today is highly personalised and data-driven. With regular testing, we can prevent many injuries that once seemed unavoidable.

Strong bones do not just build champions. They build confidence and the courage to push limits.